

to sell, put shares on the auction block, set the price, haggled with the traders, and in general did the work of an entire Wall Street investment firm. "Once you've blown away the research department, you realize you don't need to run around meeting with companies, which is another relief," he added.

"Another thing we like is that brokers never call us," Mr. LeBaron continued. "They only talk to the machine." He explained how the computer was equipped to do business with 25 human traders in various markets around the world. After these 25 signed on from their own computer terminals each morning, the Battery March brain transmitted a list of what it might want to buy or sell. The humans put in their various bids, and the computer shut down precisely at 11:00 A.M. to consider its response. If it didn't get the price it wanted, it simply took the stock in question off the trading block. If it was satisfied with the price, it came back on line to announce that the offer had been accepted.

As the two of us talked, I watched the computer offer to sell 892,800 shares of Black & Decker at \$23¼ a share. It gave no indication of any interest in Gillette.

Million-share days were not unusual for this machine. From 9:30 A.M. to 4:00 P.M. it traded the U.S. markets, then went international for the evenings, moving from east to west along the path of the sun. It bought and sold stocks in London, Rome, Hong Kong, Singapore, and Japan, and then after 21 hours of constant work, it took 3 hours off to rest and to consider what it had done.

At night it labored alone in the office, but if there was a problem it knew the home phone numbers for Dean LeBaron and other Battery March executives. In an emergency, the computer could reach them via beeper. When things ran smoothly, which was most of the time, the employees didn't find out what was bought and sold until morning.

Apparently the computer had no sentimental attachment to any stock or to any country. A babysitter named Mary Beth, who sat next to the machine in the middle of the room, told me it would "sell out entire countries if it decided those countries were unattractive."

Trading by computer had produced a very relaxed office. Neither Mary Beth nor her colleagues in the cubicles had the harried look